

Always a LYRICAL LIFE

Amit Chaudhuri's much anticipated new novel sings of love and longing in the city of music

| By Brinda Bose |

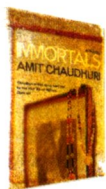
Amit Chaudhuri is a marvellous miniaturist of prose, bearing aloft an Austenian legacy, inscribing languorous soliloquies on little bits of ivory, astonishingly untouched by buffeting winds of experiment and change in our universe of ever-more-startling literary calisthenics. In a world in which an Ian McEwan, for example, produces an *Atonement*, an *Amsterdam* as well as a *Chesil Beach* and even a choppy libretto (*For You*) in the space of 10 years, Chaudhuri is unabashedly recognisable in what is clearly his forte, a mellifluous, chaste, unhurried flow of words that dips into lives that are equally chaste and unhurried, in the main—and in the case of his latest novel, supremely mellifluous as well. We might say that *The Immortals*, Chaudhuri's fifth novel, adds to his redoubtable oeuvre without deviating an inch from what you might wish from it. And if you know of Chaudhuri's passions—"music" and "writing", as the two links on his website proclaim—then here is where they cleave together in a not-unexpected union, a match made in creative wonderland, surely.

I first read Chaudhuri's short fiction in England about two decades ago, in journals like the *London Review of Books*: some of those pieces eventually went on, I think, to make up his first published novel, *A Strange and Sublime Address*, a deft sleight of fictional hand that proved its unmitigated success by winning the Betty Trask and the Commonwealth (Eurasia) awards for a first novel in 1991. *Afternoon Raag*, that followed, and his next two novels, *Freedom Song* and *A New World*, also won him numerous awards and accolades, establishing Chaudhuri as a confident, distinctive voice in Indian English writing. What marks Chaudhuri's fiction at its best is the sheer effortlessness with which his sensibilities can dart into nooks and crannies of daily lives, and return



SUVASHIS MULLICK

to spill those tales and feelings with the lazy, rolling charm of a somnolent summer day. Here is a writer almost disdainful of any excess, whether of language, living or loving; here are novels that will lure you into kitchens redolent of chicken curry and daal, of cumin and asafoetida, and slowly cleanse your palate of any residual desire for literary twists and turns of plot or phrase; and here now is the story of a mother and a son caught in an unhurried symphony with their music teacher, playing out their days and ends sometimes to his tunes and sometimes to their own, striking the odd discordant note but neither



THE IMMORTALS
by AMIT CHAUDHURI
Picador India
Price: Rs 495
Pages: 405